



Madagascan Dry Forest

A distinctive, diverse, and rapidly disappearing ecosystem, with an extremely high percentage of native plant and animal species found nowhere else on Earth

Madagascar's tropical dry forest covers about 58,300 square miles (151,000 square km), mainly in small, fragmented blocks along the island's western and northwestern coasts. Characterized by a dry season that lasts up to eight months a year, it is a habitat full of unique, sometimes bizarre-looking plants that have evolved to cope with an extreme lack of water. Seven species of baobab tree grow here—six native to Madagascar—alongside shorter species that have also

adapted to dry conditions, such as moringas and spiky succulents of the *Pachypodium* genus. The animals are also highly specialized, so much so that many—such as numerous lemurs, chameleons, and the island's largest predator, the catlike fossa—are found nowhere else. Slash-and-burn agriculture has already destroyed 97 percent of the forest and threatens the remainder.



◀ CLINGING ON

Numerous species of chameleons cling on to existence in what remains of Madagascar's dry tropical forest. The panther chameleon hunts by day in low trees or bushes.

